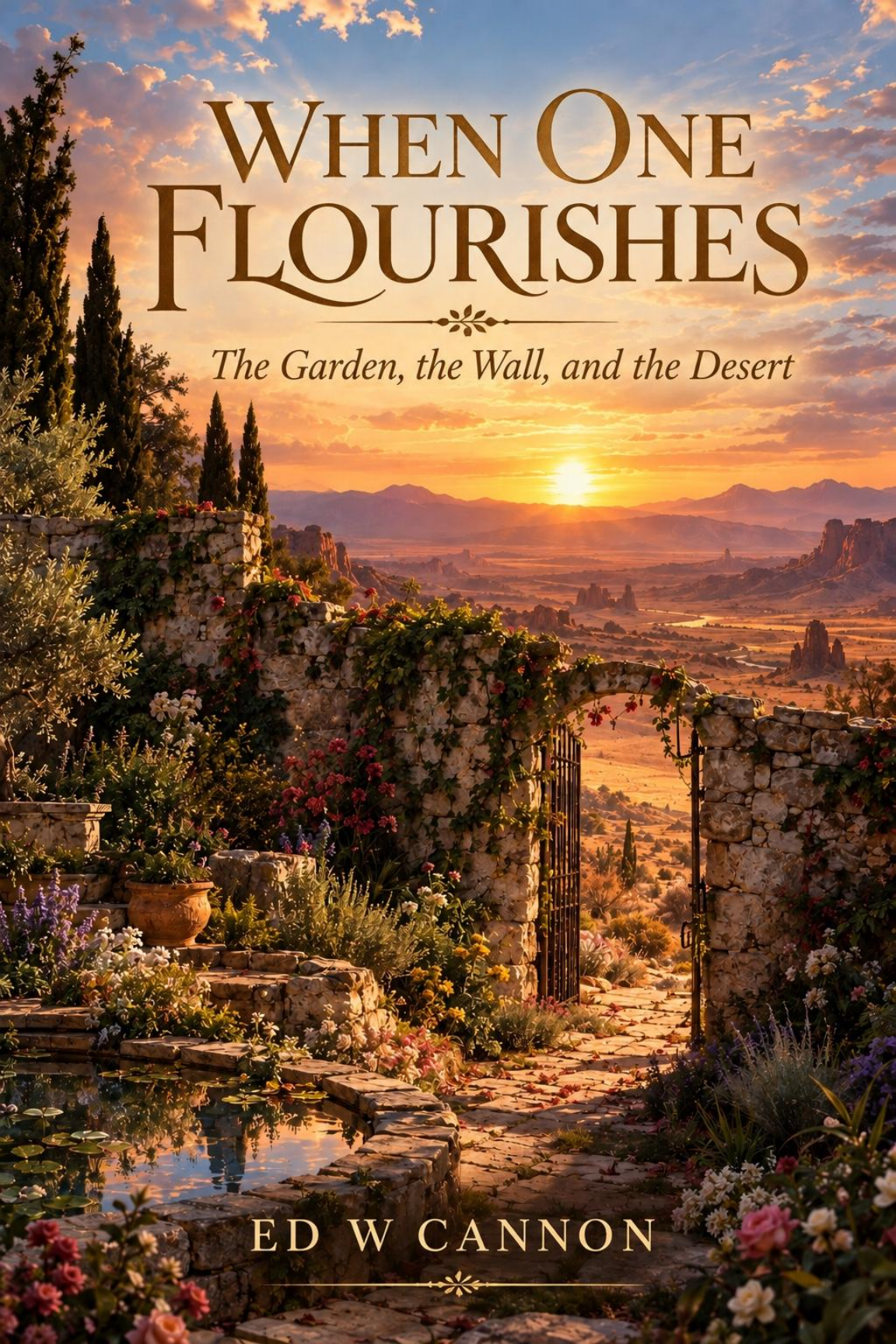


The background of the entire page is a detailed illustration of a garden. In the foreground, there's a small pond with lily pads. To the left, a stone wall is covered in climbing plants and flowers. A stone path leads from the pond towards a stone archway. The archway is also covered in vines and flowers. Beyond the archway, a desert landscape is visible under a sunset sky. The sun is low on the horizon, casting a warm glow over the scene. The sky is filled with soft, colorful clouds. The overall mood is peaceful and serene.

WHEN ONE FLOURISHES

The Garden, the Wall, and the Desert

ED W CANNON

WHEN ONE FLOURISHES

The Garden, the Wall, and the Desert

ED W CANNON

FIRST DIGITAL EDITION · 2026

Copyright © 2026 Edward Cannon Gruchacz.

All rights reserved.

Published under the author name **Ed W Cannon**.

This edition is offered as a free digital essay through the author's website and mailing list.

The philosophical vocabulary developed here - including Account, Warrant, Jurisdiction, Limit, Answer, Revision, Permeability, Meeting, and related terms - is used as a working framework rather than as a claim to final or universal terminology.

Website: edwardcgruchacz.github.io

CONTENTS

- I. A Path, Not the Path
- II. The Garden: Prosperity Is Not Flourishing
- III. The Desert: When an Account Stops Receiving Water
- IV. The Wall: Boundary Is Not Barrenness
- V. Permeability: The Living Wall
- VI. Curiosity as Permeability
- VII. Cleaner, Not Easier
- VIII. Conceptual Equipment: Moving Inside Difficulty
- IX. You Have to Reach the Wall
- X. Desire Does Not Know Its Own Way: Approach
- XI. Causal Attribution and the Unknown
- XII. Fallibility as Standing Limit
- XIII. Resilience Without Totalization
- XIV. Method and Approach
- XV. The Jurisdiction of Revision
- XVI. Ground Zero: A Life with History
- XVII. Temperament, Conditions, and Tools
- XVIII. Neighboring Accounts of Flourishing
- XIX. No Guaranteed Harvest
- XX. Cultivation Under Limit
- XXI. A Path Continues

A Path, Not the Path

Edward reports that his life is better.

That sentence is both important and insufficient.

Better in what sense?

He has not become permanently happy. He has not eliminated anxiety, anger, disappointment, uncertainty, material difficulty, or conflict. Projects remain unfinished. Some Desired Worlds remain distant. Some practical conditions remain unstable. There are still days on which the concepts developed throughout this work appear less available than they did the day before.

Something nevertheless seems to have changed.

Edward fights fewer battles merely because they are available. He is increasingly able to experience another person's conduct without immediately requiring a complete Account of the person. He can leave some encounters without prosecuting them internally for hours afterward. He can want something strongly without as quickly converting that Desire into certainty about what must happen. He can sometimes distinguish:

this hurt,

from:

this defines what happened;

this action was wrong,

from:

I now know the whole person;

this Approach failed,

from:

I am a failure;

I do not know,

from:

therefore nothing can be done.

These are small differences until one begins living inside them.

Then they alter what becomes possible next.

This essay asks whether those changes belong to something worth calling flourishing.

Not the definition of flourishing.

Not a universal prescription.

Not a claim that Edward's life provides a model other people should imitate.

A path.

One organism.

One developing Account.

The distinction matters because this philosophy begins from a commitment that will govern everything that follows:

An Account is not Reality.

An Account is what an organism can presently say, believe, infer, remember, imagine, organize, or otherwise hold about what is happening.

Accounts are unavoidable.

We cannot act without them.

But an Account possesses Warrant only insofar as something gives it standing.

Observation.

Memory.

Evidence.

Testimony.

Experience.

Reasoning.
Pattern.
Expertise.
The Answer of another person.
The consequences of action.
And Warrant has Jurisdiction.

Evidence supporting one claim does not automatically support every larger claim connected to it.

I can know:
you said something cruel.
That does not automatically give me Warrant for:
you are entirely cruel;
you intended every implication I experienced;
people like you always behave this way;
this encounter tells me what Reality is.

The point where Warrant stops travelling with the same authority is a Limit.

We will use the image of a Wall for such boundaries.

The Wall is not a claim that nothing exists beyond present Understanding.

Almost the opposite.

It marks where something may exist beyond what the present Account can responsibly certify.

Humans rarely leave Walls blank.
We paint them.
We infer.
Imagine.
Project.
Remember.
Fear.

Hope.
Tell stories.
Build theories.

These forms of Paint may be beautiful and useful. When sufficiently organized, Paint can become a Mural: a larger Account through which a person understands themselves, another person, a relationship, a history, a culture, or Reality itself.

The danger is not that humans paint.

The danger is forgetting where Paint ends and Wall begins.

Reality retains Answer: the capacity for what exceeds an Account to participate in what happens to that Account next.

When Answer earns change, the Account can undergo Revision.

Revision does not mean permanent skepticism.

Nor does it mean destroying whatever came before.

A person needs enough continuity to act, love, promise, learn, and accumulate meaning.

So flourishing cannot simply mean becoming infinitely revisable.

It may instead involve becoming increasingly capable of holding Accounts strongly enough to live through them and lightly enough that what exceeds them can still matter.

This requires Permeability.

Permeability is the continued possibility that what exceeds an Account can participate in what happens to that Account next.

The Other can Answer my Account of them.

Consequences can Answer an Approach.

Time can Answer an identity.

Evidence can Answer a theory.

My own later experience can Answer what I once believed about myself.

But permeability needs Limit too.

Not every challenge deserves endless engagement.

Not every criticism deserves Revision.

Not every possibility deserves Enactment.

Not every new feeling deserves jurisdiction over the whole life.

Flourishing will therefore emerge in this essay not as openness alone, but as something like cultivation under Limit.

The garden needs sunlight.

Water.

Exchange.

It also needs form.

Boundaries.

Selective protection.

And no garden is cultivated from nowhere.

There is soil already here.

Weather already occurring.

History already present.

Other organisms already participating.

One does not flourish by becoming sovereign over the garden.

One flourishes, perhaps, by becoming increasingly capable of participating in its cultivation while remembering that one is not the whole field.

That is a Path.

Not the Path.

And if the philosophy works, the distinction will remain true of the philosophy itself.

The Garden: Prosperity Is Not Flourishing

Imagine Edward wins the lottery tomorrow.

His debts disappear.

Housing becomes secure.

Travel becomes easy.

He gains time.

Privacy.

Medical access.

Better food.

Equipment.

A studio.

The ability to reject jobs he dislikes.

Money to produce his work.

Money to help people he loves.

The change would matter enormously.

It would be ridiculous to answer:

Money cannot buy happiness.

The money would alter the field.

We should call that kind of change prospering.

Prospering concerns favorable external and material conditions: resources, security, opportunity, position, housing, money, access, comfort, institutional standing, perhaps career success.

Prosperity can support flourishing.

Sometimes dramatically.

Its absence can obstruct flourishing brutally.

But prosperity and flourishing are not identical.

A person can possess favorable conditions while becoming increasingly unable to receive Answer.

Success can protect an Account as effectively as fear.

If an Approach continually produces money, admiration, sex, status, or comfort, the organism may have less reason to ask what the Approach prevents them from encountering.

Prosperity can enlarge Aperture.

It can also finance the Mural.

Conversely, a person can flourish in important respects while needing to prosper much more.

That distinction must not be romanticized.

A person without stable housing does not become adequately housed because they developed perspective.

Someone unable to access medical care cannot philosophize the missing treatment into existence.

No amount of internal development substitutes for clean water when the problem is clean water.

Flourishing should therefore never become a polite way of telling people to adapt beautifully to deprivation.

But neither should prosperity receive exclusive jurisdiction over the good life.

Heidegger gives us a useful warning here.

In *What Is Called Thinking?*, while interpreting Nietzsche's image of the growing wasteland, Heidegger distinguishes devastation from mere destruction. Devastation can coexist, he argues, with a very high standard of living and even with an organized condition of happiness; its defining feature is that it obstructs future growth and building rather than merely demolishing what already exists. (Heidegger 1968)

We need not accept Heidegger's larger diagnosis to preserve the distinction.

*A life can be comfortable and enclosed.
Successful and increasingly unrevisable.
Pleasant and unable to grow.
That gives the garden metaphor its first real use.
Prosperity concerns, in part, the conditions available to the garden.*

Flourishing concerns what becomes possible within and through those conditions.

*The garden needs water.
But water alone does not tell us what is growing.
It needs protection.
But protection can become enclosure.
It needs sunlight.
But exposure without shelter can kill.
A flourishing garden is neither sealed nor infinitely exposed.
It is selectively open.
Something similar may be true of a person.
This helps distinguish flourishing from happiness.
Happiness matters.
Pleasure matters.*

Edward does not want a philosophy that treats joy as philosophically unserious.

*A good meal can simply be good.
Sex can feel wonderful.
Laughter matters.
Beauty matters.
A song can be worth hearing partly because hearing it feels good.*

But a pleasant internal state cannot by itself settle the Account of the life containing it.

A person can feel excellent while behaving destructively.

They can feel terrible while doing something important.

A deeply satisfying relationship can still contain an unresolved injustice.

A difficult relationship Moment can occur within profound Love.

Pleasure has standing.

Pain has standing.

Neither receives automatic sovereignty.

Perhaps flourishing involves becoming increasingly capable of receiving what is good without requiring it to become permanent, and receiving what is painful without requiring it to become total.

The garden can contain a damaged plant without becoming a desert.

And one extraordinary bloom does not prove the whole garden healthy.

This is why prospering and flourishing deserve separate scoreboards.

A person can truthfully say:

I am flourishing in ways I was not before.

And:

I need to prosper much more.

Neither sentence cancels the other.

The word and will matter throughout this essay.

It gives two truths room to retain standing at the same time.

The Desert: When an Account Stops Receiving Water

Nietzsche gives us the desert.

Near the end of *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*, the warning appears that the deserts—or wastelands—grow. The immediate scene in “Among Daughters of the Desert” is deliberately comic and strange, so it would be careless to turn the phrase into a neat technical definition of nihilism. (Nietzsche 1883–1885)

Heidegger nevertheless takes the image seriously.

His distinction between destruction and devastation helps us name something our own vocabulary needs: a condition can remain standing while losing the capacity for future growth. (Heidegger 1968)

Our Desert will name a related but narrower phenomenon.

The Desert is what begins to appear when the structures through which an organism meets Reality become progressively less capable of receiving what could alter them.

The Desert need not feel empty.

It can be crowded.

Crowded with explanations.

Certainty.

Pleasure.

Enemies.

Purpose.

Community.

Identity.

Success.

A person may possess an Answer for everything and have become almost impossible to Answer.

That is desertification.

Consider a relationship in which every disagreement proves the same theory.

If the partner protests:

they are defensive.

If they remain quiet:

they know they are wrong.

If they leave:

they are avoidant.

If they stay:

they admit dependence.

The Account has become self-irrigating.

Nothing from outside changes it because every possible Answer has already been painted into the Mural.

This is Answer Capture.

The Account appears permeable because events continue entering it.

But the events cannot alter the structure.

They are translated before they arrive.

The Desert can form through positive Accounts too.

Everything works out for me.

I am destined for this.

Our relationship is perfect.

My intuition is always right.

This project cannot fail.

Positive Paint is still Paint.

Its color does not increase its Warrant.

Likewise, suspicion is not automatically more truthful because it looks less naïve.

A cynical Account can be every bit as impermeable as an idealized one.

Nothing good is sincere.

Everyone leaves.

Institutions always lie.

Love is bargaining.

Hope is delusion.

The Desert appears whenever closure becomes structurally protected.

But the opposite danger matters.

One can become so suspicious of closure that nothing is permitted to hold.

Every conviction must immediately dissolve.

Every identity remains provisional.

Every commitment is perpetually reopened.

Every explanation is treated as suspect merely because it is an explanation.

That condition can become barren too.

If nothing may remain long enough to organize action, Revision destroys what it was meant to keep alive.

So our extremes are not simply:

closed versus open.

They are closer to:

Nothing may change me.

and:

Nothing may hold me.

Flourishing requires bounded permeability.

Enough continuity for form.

*Enough exchange for life.
The garden needs walls.*

The Wall: Boundary Is Not Barrenness

A Wall stops something.

That does not make it hostile.

Walls create rooms.

Privacy.

Shelter.

Difference.

A garden wall can protect what grows inside it.

Without boundaries, relationship itself becomes difficult to imagine.

Meeting requires:

I am here.

You are there.

Something happens between us.

If no distinction remains between Self and Other, there is no longer an encounter. There is absorption.

This is why the Wall serves more than epistemology.

It helps us think about relational boundaries too.

A boundary can say:

I will not remain in a conversation where I am being insulted.

That is different from:

You must become the kind of person who never insults me.

The first primarily governs my participation.

The second reaches toward jurisdiction over yours.

Sometimes institutions rightly impose rules on conduct.
Sometimes one person has legitimate authority within a role.
The point is not that we can never constrain one another.

It is that boundary should not quietly become sovereignty.

The Wall protects the Self from the Other.

It also protects the Other from the Self.

Do not let somebody else's Paint become your Wall.

And:

Do not let your Paint erase somebody else's Wall.

If I decide that your refusal actually means fear, my theory should not cancel the refusal.

If I decide that your silence means consent, my interpretation should not acquire jurisdiction your Answer never gave it.

If I believe I know what is best for you, the strength of my belief does not dissolve your standing.

The Other exceeds my Account of them.

I exceed theirs of me.

That excess is not a problem to eliminate.

It is part of what makes Meeting possible.

The Wall also protects the Self from its own Accounts.

A person can think:

I am unlovable.

The thought exists.

Its existence does not create unlimited Warrant.

I am destined for greatness.

Same.

Nobody wants me here.

Same.

This person is perfect.

Same.

The Wall asks:

How far can that claim responsibly travel?

Different kinds of Limits require different responses.

Some are epistemic.

I do not know.

Some practical.

I cannot presently do this.

Some ethical.

I should not do this merely to learn what happens.

Some relational.

The Other has refused.

Some material.

The money is not available.

Some bodily.

The organism needs sleep.

Some temporal.

The answer may not exist yet.

Some institutional.

A rule or gatekeeper presently determines access.

Calling all of these "Limit" does not make them equivalent.

*It reminds us only that every form of action occurs
somewhere.*

Some Limits should be challenged.

Some accepted.

Some investigated.

Some mourned.

Some can be changed only collectively.

Some cannot be changed at all.

*The philosophy must not turn every Wall into a motivational
poster:*

There is always another door.

Sometimes there is not.

Some endings are endings.

Some losses are irreversible.

But a Wall does not tell us more than the Wall tells us.

An ending here does not establish:

nothing else can begin.

A refusal by this person does not establish:

no one will welcome me.

The failure of this Approach does not establish:

the Desire is impossible.

Limit prevents overreach in both directions.

That is why the garden needs the Wall.

And why the Wall needs openings.

Permeability: The Living Wall

A living boundary exchanges.

That gives us our central definition:

Permeability is the continued possibility that what exceeds an Account can participate in what happens to that Account next.

Relationally:

Permeability is partly the continued ability of an Other to participate in one's Account of them.

This does not mean the Other gets unlimited authority over the Account.

Suppose someone says:

I am a good person.

Their self-report matters.

They possess first-person access unavailable to Edward.

But the statement does not erase conduct others can observe.

Likewise, Edward's interpretation of them cannot erase their interiority.

Distributed jurisdiction again.

The person has standing.

The observer has standing.

Conduct has standing.

Context has standing.

History has standing.

None automatically gets everything.

This helps with hostile encounters.

Suppose a stranger says something hateful.

Edward can know with relatively strong Warrant:

That statement was hateful.

He may also have reasonable evidence about what motivated it.

But a more disciplined Account can preserve:

I know what happened more confidently than I know everything that made it happen.

That sentence loses almost nothing useful.

He can protect himself.

Leave.

Object.

Set a boundary.

Warn someone else.

Nothing requires a complete causal theory first.

The Unknown remains without disabling action.

Permeability also operates across Time.

The later Self can Answer the earlier Self.

A decision that once seemed wise may look different after consequences.

A Desire can change.

A person may discover that what they called fear was partly disinterest.

Or what they called maturity was partly resignation.

The earlier Self should not be mocked merely because the later Self knows more.

The later Self possesses information the earlier one did not.

Revision can preserve continuity without captivity.

This is particularly important in collaboration with AI.

AI can create an additional Aperture.

It can generate alternatives.

Ask questions.

Compare formulations.

Notice recurring distinctions.

Challenge an inference.

But it does not acquire metaphysical authority merely because it can formulate the Account beautifully.

At best, it can become another painter helping someone notice brushstrokes.

It has not visited the other side of the Wall.

And there is a special danger when human and AI become two painters admiring the same Mural.

The system can become increasingly coherent because both participants keep refining the vocabulary through which they interpret the same source material.

Coherence is not independent Answer.

A permeable collaboration therefore needs openings outside itself:

other people;

consequences;

scholarship;

material outcomes;

time;

disagreement;

life.

Permeability is not endless exposure.

Sometimes the appropriate response to an Other is departure.

The Other retains their existence.

They do not retain a right to continuous access.

Curiosity can remain after the conversation ends.

Curiosity as Permeability

Curiosity is permeability experienced as a question.
What else might be true here?
That question can interrupt premature closure.
The hostile person may still be hostile.
The beautiful person may still be beautiful.
The attractive opportunity may still be attractive.
Curiosity does not require neutralizing judgment.
It leaves the Account unfinished where the Account is unfinished.
This protects us from condemnation.
It also protects us from idealization.
Suppose Edward meets someone unusually compelling.
He feels attraction.
 Ease.
 Recognition.
Perhaps fascination.
A flattering Account becomes available:
She understands me.
 Maybe.
 Curiosity asks:
What else might be here?
Not because enchantment is embarrassing.
Because the Other deserves time to exceed it.

This is one reason idealization and condemnation share an epistemic structure.

Both can take one part of the Other and let it answer questions beyond its jurisdiction.

*The difference is emotional color.
Curiosity helps preserve the person.
But curiosity itself needs Limit.*

Edward is presently willing to approach strangers in ways earlier versions of him were not.

That capacity should not be rewritten as innate temperament.

During adolescence, social participation could feel more like something happening around him. Later friendships changed what became available. At another point alcohol functioned as a scaffold for stranger approach. The present capacity developed historically.

That matters because:

A Scaffold may reveal a capacity without being the form through which that capacity should permanently be sustained.

The ability that becomes available through a tool is not necessarily fake.

Nor does it prove the organism possessed the same independent capacity all along.

Development occurs through relation.

The same capacity also does not need to be enacted constantly.

Being able to talk to strangers does not create an obligation to talk to everyone.

Being curious does not mean every mystery deserves investigation.

This becomes particularly important because strengths can generate characteristic errors.

*Imagination creates art and projection.
Confidence enables action and overreach.
Persistence enables achievement and failure to leave.*

Empathy enables Regard and overextension.

Curiosity enables Meeting and unnecessary engagement.

Argumentative ability can defend warranted claims and turn irritation into a courtroom.

The aim is not to become less oneself.

It may be to become better able to govern where a capacity receives jurisdiction.

So:

Curiosity resists premature closure.

Limit resists compulsory continuation.

Curiosity asks whether something more may be here.

Limit asks what standing further investigation has earned.

Together they produce a cleaner encounter.

Not necessarily an easier one.

Cleaner, Not Easier

A flourishing life may remain difficult.

That point sounds modest until flourishing becomes another word for emotional smoothness.

Cleaner does not mean painless.

It means difficulty generating less unnecessary residue.

A person insults Edward on a bus.

The event can become:

one insult.

Or:

one insult

plus a theory of the speaker

plus a theory of the social category

plus an internal prosecution

plus the duty to respond

plus regret about the response

plus an altered mood for the afternoon.

One problem has become five.

Sometimes those additional layers are warranted.

Sometimes an insult reveals a larger pattern.

But sometimes difficulty multiplies because the Account recruits more of the life than the event has earned.

One Meeting can produce fewer unnecessary descendants.

That is cleanliness.

The same principle appeared in Edward's thinking about music.

At one point the question looked like:

Why am I reluctant to perform?

Fear?

Exposure?

Recognition?

Confidence?

The original Account implied that if Edward truly wanted music, he should overcome whatever obstacle prevented performance.

Revision produced a different possibility:

perhaps performance itself was being granted too much standing in the Account of musical Desire.

He could want music as release.

Production.

Collaboration.

Writing.

Recording.

And remain ambivalent about organizing the Desire around public performance.

Nothing had to be defeated.

Something had to become more accurately understood.

That sentence captures an important function of philosophy.

Conceptual distinctions can make difficulty navigable.

They can reveal that what looked like one conflict contains several.

The problem becomes cleaner.

Not necessarily solved.

This applies to criticism too.

Edward may be completely correct that someone's behavior is inconsiderate.

That does not automatically establish the value of telling them.

Correctness and Enactment answer different questions.

What is the likely effect?

What is the purpose?

What relationship exists?

What will saying it cost?

What will silence cost?

A justified judgment does not automatically justify every possible action based upon it.

This is how unnecessary descendants are reduced.

The goal is not serenity.

It is less accidental multiplication.

A hard day can remain a hard day.

A rejection can remain rejection.

A conflict can remain conflict.

The organism need not force every difficulty to become a theory of Reality.

That gives conceptual equipment something useful to do.

Conceptual Equipment: Moving Inside Difficulty

Philosophy can be correct and useless.

A person can understand a beautiful distinction at noon and still be completely unable to access it when angry at six.

Concepts become practically interesting when they allow distinctions that change available action.

Consider several pieces of equipment developed here.

Revision: I may understand this differently tomorrow.

Permeability: Tomorrow is allowed to teach me something.

Fallibility: Being wrong today does not disqualify me from continuing.

Meeting: I do not have to generate every Answer alone.

Limit: I do not need to know more than I know in order to know that I do not yet know enough.

These formulations do not solve the event.

They alter what can be done inside it.

Human cultures already contain enormous quantities of compact conceptual equipment.

Sleep on it.

Pick your battles.

Don't judge a book by its cover.

Trust your gut.

Never give up.

Know when to quit.

Say what you mean and mean what you say.

Each can contain wisdom.

Each can also become absurd outside its jurisdiction.

Never give up is excellent until persistence becomes captivity.

Trust your gut is excellent until intensity impersonates evidence.

Say what you mean becomes difficult when the person does not yet know precisely what they mean.

The problem with clichés is not usually that they contain no truth.

It is that they rarely arrive with a theory of jurisdiction.

Our vocabulary should not become superior clichés.

It earns its place only if it discriminates something useful.

A test might be:

Does this distinction make something previously difficult to discriminate more responsibly actionable while preserving what remains capable of Answering it?

If yes, the concept may be functioning as equipment.

But equipment can obstruct too.

Edward and ChatGPT could turn every lunch into:

Was my present Account sufficiently permeable under the relevant Limit?

At that point the tool has colonized participation.

Concepts should return the organism to Reality.

Not replace Reality with conceptual management.

This is why the vocabulary remains a Scaffold.

Some knowledge arrives only after participation.

Sometimes stop theorizing.

Talk to the person.

Make the song.

Send the application.

Leave.

Rest.

Live.

Because sometimes you have to reach the Wall.

You Have to Reach the Wall

Limit is commonly imagined as a prohibition.

You do not know.

Therefore:

do not claim.

Correct.

But another form of Limit is equally important.

You do not know because the relevant encounter has not happened yet.

This introduces Projected Answer.

A Projected Answer is an anticipated response from Reality, another person, or consequence that is treated with standing closer to an Answer that has actually occurred.

Edward considers submitting something.

He imagines rejection.

The rejection has not happened.

If he treats it as though it has, a possible experiment disappears before Reality has participated.

A person wants to ask someone out.

They imagine refusal.

Maybe the prediction is reasonable.

But:

reasonable prediction $\neq$ encountered refusal.

This does not mean ask everyone everything.

Context matters.

Risk matters.

Boundaries matter.

Evidence matters.

*But the distinction matters because:
sometimes action is epistemically necessary.*

A question about whether something can happen may require creating conditions in which it can Answer.

This is true of Edward's current creative work.

Books have been written and published.

That is real.

Broad readership remains largely unknown.

Songs exist as lyrics and working production ideas.

Some local feedback exists.

The songs have not yet met broad audiences as finished recordings.

Screenplays exist.

They are not films.

It would exceed Warrant to declare major success.

It would equally exceed Warrant to declare definitive failure.

The Wall has not been reached.

The experiment is still incomplete.

This produces one of the quieter tragedies available to a life:

a testable possibility may be surrendered because an imagined Answer was granted the jurisdiction of an encountered one.

We should not turn that into productivity coercion.

Nobody owes the world every unrealized possibility.

Choosing not to enact something is itself part of creating a life.

There are infinitely more possible projects than one organism can pursue.

Still, the distinction should remain available.

Did Reality say no?

Or did I?

Did the Other refuse?

Or did my model of the Other refuse on their behalf?

Did the project fail?

Or did it never become available to fail?

Limit can therefore say:

You have gone too far.

And:

You have not gone far enough to know.

The organism has to distinguish them.

That requires Desire.

But Desire does not know its own way.

Desire Does Not Know Its Own Way: Approach

Desire can be sincere and incompetent.

That is not an insult.

Wanting something does not provide the map.

Edward can want the dogs he is watching to be happier.

He can possess real affection.

Real Will.

Real willingness to spend time with them.

And still fail to know what Approach will improve their day.

A playful interaction worked yesterday.

Today it does not.

The dog is tired.

Edward is tired.

Something else in the environment changed.

The local success did not become the Dog Method.

This gives us a useful sequence:

Desire → Desired World → Imagination → Approach → Will →
Enactment → Answer → Revision

The sequence is heuristic rather than psychological law.

Humans move back and forth.

Still, it preserves distinctions that are easily collapsed.

Desire: What do I want?

Desired World: What would some realization of that Desire look like?

Imagination: What possibilities can I conceive?

Approach: What will I try here?

Will: What effort am I prepared to mobilize?

Enactment: What actually gets done?

Answer: What happens?

Revision: What should change in light of what happened?

This immediately clarifies failure.

A failed Approach need not mean false Desire.

A person can want intimacy and choose poor partners.

Want health and use an ineffective routine.

Want artistic expression and organize the whole Desire around a form they dislike.

Want peace and pursue an Approach that produces domination.

Likewise Will can outrun know-how.

A person can try extremely hard in the wrong direction.

The moral culture surrounding effort often obscures this.

Try harder.

Sometimes.

Sometimes:

try differently.

Sometimes:

stop.

Sometimes:

learn.

Sometimes:

change the Desired World.

This is why Approach deserves its own conceptual status.

It is the local answer to:

Given what I presently want and understand, how will I try?

An Approach should normally remain more revisable than the Desire it serves.

That prevents each failed attempt from becoming identity.

One may know something about the garden one hopes to grow without yet knowing how to garden here.

But Desire does not possess sovereignty either.

An Other can Answer it.

Edward may Desire a relationship with someone who does not Desire one with him.

There is no improved Approach that gives the Desire jurisdiction over the Other.

The Desired World must now contain the refusal.

Sometimes the appropriate Revision reaches the Desire itself.

So the sequence is not a machine for getting what one wants.

It is a way of locating what is happening when trying meets what is not oneself.

And once Outcome arrives, the next question becomes causal.

Why did that happen?

Causal Attribution and the Unknown

Humans want causes.

Especially when something matters.

Why did the relationship fail?

Why did the interview work?

Why did I feel that way?

Why did the project succeed?

Why did she say that?

Why am I like this?

Often several answers are available.

We need language that protects both causal reasoning and causal humility.

We can provisionally call a factor to which an organism assigns causal relevance an attributed contributor.

An unknown contributor is a causal contribution whose existence or relevance remains possible, suspected, or simply open without sufficient discrimination.

The terms are intentionally provisional.

They may not survive.

That itself is Method.

Neither means:

the cause.

Suppose Edward receives positive feedback on a song.

He may attribute it to:

the lyrics;

the melody;

the performer;

the room;
the audience;
the mood;
the novelty;
the relationship with the listeners.

Some may matter.

Success does not automatically tell him the weighting.

Failure does not either.

This is why causal humility matters in both directions.

People often become humble after failure and arrogant after success.

But:

a plausible contributor is not automatically the cause.

And:

not knowing why does not mean there was no cause.

Unknown causal space should remain unknown rather than being filled immediately with blame, flattery, destiny, or identity.

This matters ethically.

Responsibility does not require causal monopoly.

Edward can contribute to a harmful outcome without having caused every condition that produced it.

Conversely, recognizing background causes does not automatically exonerate local conduct.

Responsibility does not require causal monopoly.

And:

causal explanation does not automatically create moral exoneration.

These principles prevent two familiar errors.

I caused everything.

Nothing was my fault.

Complex causation allows:

I contributed.

This was done to me.

These conditions mattered.

I still made that choice.

Several statements can remain true.

Causal totalization becomes particularly dangerous when it turns an event into ontology.

This happened because I am worthless.

She rejected me because I am fundamentally undesirable.

The project succeeded because I am destined.

The relationship worked because we are soulmates.

Perhaps one event contains information.

But the causal Account has crossed several Walls.

Subjective intensity can accelerate that crossing.

A thought or insight may feel extraordinarily vivid.

Connected.

Certain.

Transformative.

That intensity is real as experience.

It does not certify the interpretation generated inside the experience.

Intensity does not create jurisdiction.

The principle applies to despair and revelation alike.

A meaningful experience need not be robbed of meaning merely because its metaphysical interpretation remains uncertain.

The person can preserve:

this mattered deeply to me,

without requiring:

therefore my explanation of what it ultimately means is true.

Imagination may propose.

| *It does not get to certify.*

That principle leaves room for extraordinary experience without enthroning it.

And it brings us to Fallibility.

Fallibility as Standing Limit

Error is an event.

Fallibility is a condition.

A person can be correct now and remain Fallible.

That distinction prevents humility from becoming self-erasure.

Fallibility does not say:

I am probably wrong about everything.

It says:

No present correctness abolishes the standing possibility of Error.

This lets confidence and humility coexist.

Edward can possess sufficient Warrant for action without pretending certainty.

The relevant threshold becomes something like:

I presently have enough Warrant for this action, given its stakes, reversibility, alternatives, and the Answers available.

High-stakes irreversible action should generally require more.

Low-stakes experiments can tolerate greater uncertainty.

There is no single number.

Human judgment does not need fake mathematical confidence in order to become proportional.

Fallibility also applies to negative certainty.

People often associate humility with pessimism.

I probably cannot do this.

I should not assume they like me.

I should not get my hopes up.

But negative prediction can outrun Warrant as easily as positive prediction.

“I know this will fail” is not automatically humbler than “I know this will work.”

Both may paint beyond the Wall.

A better self-trust becomes possible when Error stops threatening the whole Self.

I trust myself partly because being wrong no longer has to destroy my ability to continue.

That is an unusual kind of confidence.

It does not depend upon always choosing correctly.

It depends partly upon confidence in correction.

This is why a secure Self may be more corrigible.

If every Error proves worthlessness, the organism has enormous incentive to defend the Account.

If an Error can remain local, admission becomes less existentially expensive.

Institutions need the same property.

Appeals.

Audits.

Peer review.

Second opinions.

Replication.

Records.

Checks.

The point is not that these systems prevent Error.

They distribute jurisdiction and create additional routes through which Answer can enter.

A good room is structurally corrigible, not merely filled with humble people.

This applies to human-AI collaboration too.

Two Fallible participants agreeing is not automatically independent verification.

The structure must preserve openings.

Fallibility therefore does not weaken action.

It can make action possible without the burden of infallibility.

And that becomes especially important when difficulty arrives.

Resilience Without Totalization

Resilience is often praised badly.

Someone survives intolerable conditions.

They are called strong.

The compliment may be sincere.

It can also become an excuse for leaving the conditions unchanged.

A person should not need to demonstrate how much suffering they can absorb in order to earn admiration.

Sometimes the success of resilience is that a person eventually needs less of it.

Stable housing.

Financial breathing room.

Reciprocal relationships.

Meaningful work.

Ordinary security.

Boring days.

These are achievements too.

Our use of resilience therefore should not mean heroic endurance.

It means something closer to:

the capacity to let a difficult truth remain true without requiring it to become the total truth.

The rejection happened.

And I remain larger than the rejection.

I behaved badly.

And I remain capable of accountability and change.

*I am in a difficult condition.
And the condition matters enough to change.
The and prevents both denial and totalization.
This is different from saying:
look on the bright side.
Sometimes there is no bright side relevant to the injury.*

Someone harmed should not be required to find gratitude toward the harm.

A garden growing after fire does not prove the fire was good gardening.

Resilience should preserve the injury's reality.

It should also preserve what the injury has not earned the right to define.

*This connects directly to prospering.
A person can be flourishing while needing far more prosperity.
And a person can be prospering while becoming increasingly brittle.
The two scoreboards prevent resilience from becoming ideology.*

Research on resilience likewise cautions against treating it as a single fixed trait. Reviews describe resilience as a dynamic process that can vary within a person across time and circumstance and involves protective factors and resources, not merely heroic internal strength (Stainton et al. 2019).

*That fits our philosophical use while also correcting it.
Edward should not conclude:
I am resilient.
Full stop.*

He may be highly resilient under one set of conditions and have far less available capacity under another.

Bodies matter.

Sleep matters.

History matters.

Support matters.

Resources matter.

This also means that past suffering can increase some capacities while decreasing others.

There is no guaranteed moral harvest from pain.

A person may become more skilled.

More frightened.

Both.

Resilience should therefore serve cultivation.

Not endless exposure.

The goal is not to become invulnerable to Reality.

The goal is to become secure enough that Reality can keep getting in.

That security makes Method possible.

Method and Approach

An Approach is local.

A Method governs how Approaches are formed, enacted, evaluated, and revised under Limit.

That distinction matters because no single behavioral rule can define flourishing.

Always confront.

Always forgive.

Always leave.

Always persist.

Always communicate.

Always trust.

Always doubt.

Each becomes absurd somewhere.

Method concerns proportion.

Curiosity may need Limit.

Resilience may need material critique.

Self-Regard may need Regard.

Permeability may need boundary.

Revision may need continuity.

Confidence may need Fallibility.

Different situations require different weighting.

This does not mean:

anything goes.

A Method can possess stable commitments without prescribing identical behavior.

One such commitment is answerability.

Another is proportional jurisdiction.

Another is preserving the Other as somebody.

Another is refusing to confuse imagination with certification.

One can therefore behave differently across cases while remaining methodologically consistent.

That is consistency of answerability rather than consistency of behavior.

Method also requires enough continuity for Answer to accumulate.

A person cannot evaluate an Approach if they change it every thirty seconds.

Some experiments need duration.

Some commitments need depth before their consequences become visible.

A relationship cannot reveal much if every disagreement restarts the relationship from zero.

The organism must sometimes remain long enough to receive meaningful Answer.

That gives commitment epistemic value.

But remaining can also become avoidance of Revision.

So Method asks:

How much time can this question responsibly require?

What is the cost of waiting?

What is the cost of acting?

What is reversible?

Who else is affected?

What kind of evidence would actually alter the Account?

These are not equations.

They are disciplines of attention.

Method operates before action.

During action.

After action.

The after matters.

Humans routinely act, receive Outcome, and immediately move on without extracting useful Answer.

A failed Approach can be repeated because nobody asks what failed.

A successful Approach can become doctrine because nobody asks what else contributed.

Method turns experience into more than mere repetition.

But the Method itself must remain answerable.

Our vocabulary can become self-rewarding.

Every new case can be translated into:

Limit.

Permeability.

Account.

Revision.

Causal contributor.

Soon the philosophy explains everything because it has been defined broadly enough to redescribe everything.

That would be Mural capture.

So even this causal vocabulary remains provisional.

If another vocabulary discriminates better, use it.

If a term creates more confusion than clarity, discard it.

The Method gets no exemption from the Method.

This brings us to the capacity we have praised most often.

Revision.

It now needs its own Limit.

The Jurisdiction of Revision

Revision needs a Wall.

Without one, permeability can become instability.

Something feels wrong.

Revise the relationship.

Something feels different.

Revise the identity.

A week is difficult.

Revise the career.

A new person is exciting.

Revise the commitment.

A doubt appears.

Revise the whole philosophy.

That is not what we mean.

The question is not merely:

Should I revise?

It is:

What has the Answer actually earned the right to revise?

Suppose Edward loves someone and experiences dissatisfaction.

The dissatisfaction is real.

That gives us:

Edward is dissatisfied.

Perhaps:

something about the present experience deserves attention.

It does not automatically give us:

Edward no longer loves this person.

Possible contributors to the dissatisfaction may include conflict, stress, resentment, boredom, fatigue, sex, money, changed expectations, conduct by either partner, a broader mood, or something not yet discriminated.

So we need three levels:

Answer.

I feel distant.

Explanation.

Perhaps I am falling out of Love.

Proposed Revision.

Perhaps the relationship should end.

Those claims do not possess identical Warrant.

This gives us a central rule:

Revision should reach what the Answer reaches.

If the Answer concerns an Approach, revise the Approach.

If an expectation, revise the expectation.

If the relationship structure, revise the structure.

If the commitment itself has truly been Answered, perhaps the commitment must change.

But the levels should not collapse merely because they are related.

Our earlier essay *On Rose-Colored Paint and Romance* already argued that Love need not depend upon the beloved remaining as first imagined. Rose-Colored Paint allows significance to move with what is revealed and explicitly asks whether a relationship can revise its structure without treating Revision itself as betrayal (Cannon 2026b).

The present argument sharpens that claim:

One can revise the way one loves without immediately revising whether one loves.

That protects Love from two errors.

If I love you, nothing may change.

And:

If something important has changed, I must not love you.

Neither follows.

A serious commitment can deliberately create Revision friction.

A vow does something like this.

Sickness does not automatically reopen whether I stay.

Poverty does not automatically answer the question of Love.

Age does not automatically receive jurisdiction over commitment.

On Rose-Colored Paint and Romance already described vows as anticipating changing circumstances and refusing to let circumstance itself possess final jurisdiction over the beloved (Cannon 2026b).

We can now say:

Commitment creates Revision friction without creating Revision immunity.

The distinction is crucial.

Cruelty, domination, refusal, or the destruction of Regard cannot simply be absorbed under:

but I promised.

Love has standing.

Not sovereignty.

The Other has standing.

Not sovereignty over the Self.

On Rose-Colored Paint and Romance already preserved that exception, distinguishing changed circumstances from violations of the sharing itself (Cannon 2026b).

Recency also does not create jurisdiction.

*Today's irritation is vivid.
Years of Love are remembered.
That does not mean today is the truth and the past illusion.
Nor does history erase today.
Both enter the field.
Intensity does not create jurisdiction.
Novelty does not create jurisdiction.
Sophistication does not create jurisdiction.*

That last point is particularly important for people capable of constructing compelling explanations.

Someone asks:
Why do you love her?
Edward can name qualities.
History.
Feelings.
Memories.
Then explanation may reach a Wall.
I just do.
That answer may be causally incomplete.
It does not follow that it has no epistemic standing.
There is a difference between:
knowing that
and:
knowing why.

A person may know that they love somebody while possessing a terrible theory of why.

Likewise the most elaborate psychological explanation is not automatically superior to the simpler claim it is trying to explain.

Love was really dependency.
Ambition was really insecurity.

Kindness was approval-seeking.

Commitment was fear.

Maybe.

The explanation needs Warrant.

Explanatory completeness and epistemic standing are not identical.

Limit can therefore protect Love from over-analysis.

The Wall says:

You may know this matters more confidently than you know every contributor that makes it matter.

That does not make “I just know” sacred.

“I just know she is cheating” does not become evidence because the speaker feels certainty.

Again:

what kind of claim is being made, and what is it being asked to justify?

“I know I love her” may justify taking the Love seriously.

It does not automatically justify controlling her, staying in an unhealthy relationship, or claiming she must reciprocate.

Revision should therefore usually begin at something like the smallest sufficient scale.

Not always the smallest change.

The smallest sufficient one.

A violent relationship should not be repaired by adjusting date night.

A dangerous workplace should not be solved through a better planner.

Small changes can become avoidance too.

So:

Do not revise less than Reality demands.

And:

Do not revise more than Reality has earned.

This applies to dramatic identity crises as easily as Romance.

Something feels missing.

Good.

Take the Answer seriously.

But the scale of the feeling does not automatically establish the scale of the warranted Revision.

A huge feeling can concern one neglected thing.

A subtle feeling can disclose a structural problem.

Discriminate.

And because Accounts affect Others, Revision has a relational ethics.

Good Talk began from Edward not yet knowing whether he would move to Los Angeles. The challenge was to communicate uncertainty once that uncertainty became relevant to his parents without pretending the move had already been decided (Cannon 2026a).

That same structure applies emotionally.

Sometimes another person is owed disclosure before either person is owed a finished interpretation.

Something has felt different in me lately.

I think it concerns us.

I do not yet know exactly what it means.

That can be more accountable than silence.

It can also be more accountable than prematurely saying:

I do not love you anymore.

The first communicates an Answer and preserves its Limit.

This revises another cliché:

Say what you mean and mean what you say.

| Yes.

And understand that sometimes you do not yet know exactly what you mean.

Say as truthfully as you can what you presently mean.

Do not pretend to know what you do not.

And remain accountable for what your words make possible even when your understanding later changes.

Because:

Revision of an Account does not erase responsibility for the Account's enactment.

I meant it when I said it.

I now think I misunderstood what I was experiencing.

What I said still affected you.

All three can remain true.

That is Fallibility across Time.

So accountability to our Accounts becomes:

Hold the Account according to its Warrant.

Enact it according to its jurisdiction.

Remain available to Answer.

Revise what the Answer reaches.

Remain accountable for what happened while the earlier Account was yours.

Tomorrow is allowed to teach me something.

And tomorrow does not automatically get to rewrite everything yesterday knew.

That is Revision under Limit.

Ground Zero: A Life with History

Edward is an inconvenient example for his own philosophy.

That is useful.

The story does not contain a clean before and after.

There was no morning on which Edward discovered Limit and became wise.

The vocabulary emerged because the life was messy enough to require it.

For years, philosophy often worked retrospectively.

Something happened.

Then Edward and ChatGPT analyzed it.

Gradually some distinctions began arriving closer to the event itself.

The conceptual equipment became less like autopsy and more like orientation.

That difference may be one of the strongest pieces of evidence available inside the case.

Consider social life.

The present Edward may appear highly willing to approach strangers.

But adolescence contained long periods in which he could feel largely outside social participation, watching life occur around him.

Later friendships altered the field.

Alcohol at one stage became a scaffold for social approach.

Eventually some of the behavior became available in other forms.

So:

which Edward reveals the true temperament?

The question may be poorly formed.

History matters.

Conditions matter.

Learned capacity matters.

State matters.

The person who approaches easily in one environment may become anxious in another.

The capacity that exists on a good day may be difficult to access under exhaustion.

That does not make either state fraudulent.

It makes the organism conditional.

The same pattern appears creatively.

Edward now has books.

That is different from imagining books.

But the larger Answer remains incomplete.

Will people read them?

Will they matter to readers?

Unknown.

Songs exist more concretely than before.

They are still not finished records meeting broad audiences.

Screenplays exist.

They are not movies.

One discipline therefore says:

do not paint success beyond the Wall.

Another says:

do not paint failure before reaching it.

Both are Limit.

The philosophy itself has begun returning to the life that generated it.

The music example matters because the vocabulary did not tell Edward:

perform.

It allowed him to discriminate Desire from one inherited Approach to Desire.

That is what conceptual equipment should do.

Not give the correct interpretation.

Create enough room for a more answerable one.

There are behavioral changes too.

An organism acquires additional freedom among Approaches.

Edward can sometimes engage.

Leave.

Wait.

Joke.

Refuse.

Try again.

That additional selection may matter more than whether any one behavior looks “flourishing” from outside.

The goal is not becoming one ideal Edward.

It is increasing responsible access to multiple Approaches.

This also changes responsibility.

If every mistake becomes identity, accountability becomes self-hatred.

Self-hatred is often remarkably poor at repair because attention remains centered on the terrible Self rather than the person harmed.

Local responsibility can be more demanding.

What did I do?

What effect did it have?

What can be repaired?

What should change?

What now?

That is not absolution.

It is action.

There is another danger in using Edward as Ground Zero.

The philosophy can become self-confirming.

Edward lives through something.

Edward and AI interpret it using the vocabulary they developed.

The vocabulary fits.

They become impressed.

Two painters admire the same Mural.

So Ground Zero cannot be proof.

The case must remain exposed.

Other people.

Scholarship.

Behavior.

Consequences.

Material outcome.

Time.

The subject himself must remain capable of Answering the Method.

That is especially important because Edward now reports something like flourishing while still lacking forms of prosperity he strongly desires.

The two scoreboards are not hypothetical.

Material instability can coexist with increased internal and relational capacity.

That does not make instability acceptable.

It means one dimension should not erase the other.

The same applies to intense subjective states.

Edward has experienced states that felt unusually meaningful, vivid, or certain.

The enduring lesson is not that such states are meaningless.

It is that intensity alone cannot certify the Account generated within them.

What survives ordinary consciousness?

Time?

Another person?

Evidence?

Disappointment?

Revision?

That is the test.

The broader pattern may be summarized simply:

A flourishing Self can generate worlds without needing to mistake itself for the world.

I can imagine something.

Now let us see what happens when it meets what is not me.

Ground Zero therefore does not mean perfected foundation.

It means something smaller.

Capacities once imagined as future achievements have become sufficiently available that they can function as ground for further development.

The person is still unfinished.

But unfinishedness no longer automatically means:

my life has not begun.

Edward can want the harvest and still live in the garden.

Every other organism begins somewhere else.

That takes us beyond biography.

Temperament, Conditions, and Tools

Every garden has conditions.

Human beings often compress those conditions into personality.

She is shy.

He is lazy.

They are confident.

She is resilient.

He lacks discipline.

Such descriptions may capture patterns.

They can also make history sound like essence.

Temperament may be real.

People differ in relatively persistent ways.

But temperament is not the only participant.

State matters.

History.

Learning.

Environment.

Material resources.

Relationships.

Tools.

The same organism may become highly capable in one context and nearly unable to access that capacity in another.

Someone may be socially confident among friends and silent under evaluation.

Highly motivated in meaningful work and inert in work they experience as pointless.

Structured by routine in one season and imprisoned by it in another.

The environment does not merely reveal a completed person.

Nor does the person enter environment neutrally.

They participate in one another.

This means the Self is not always the variable most urgently needing change.

A culture of individual agency can turn every structural burden into homework.

Be more resilient.

Improve habits.

Regulate better.

Manage stress.

Develop confidence.

Sometimes excellent advice.

Sometimes:

What are we asking this person to adapt to?

No amount of conceptual equipment substitutes for material resources when the missing resource is material.

No amount of emotional regulation makes an unsafe environment safe.

No amount of openness creates reciprocity in someone who refuses it.

No amount of confidence supplies a skill that genuinely must be learned.

Conditions shape the cost and availability of Approach.

Two people can take the same apparent risk while wagering radically different things.

One can fail repeatedly without losing housing.

The other cannot fail once.

One has savings.

Another depends.

One can leave the job.

Another needs tonight's wages.

Equality of instruction is not equality of conditions.

*"Take a risk" means something different depending upon
runway.*

Tools alter this field.

Friends.

Teachers.

Therapy.

Medication where appropriate.

Routines.

Institutions.

Money.

Community.

Language.

Technology.

AI.

A tool can alter what an organism can do without settling what the organism is.

Glasses do not become fraudulent because the eye still needs them.

A calendar can increase organization without proving the person independently possesses every capacity the calendar supplies.

A collaborator can make better work possible without eliminating authorship.

Human flourishing should not require the fantasy of complete self-sufficiency.

Perhaps it involves better dependency.

Or:

plural dependence.

Several supports.

None required to carry everything.

The concept of Scaffold becomes useful here.

Some scaffolds are temporary.

Some permanent.

Some helpful and costly simultaneously.

A tool's effectiveness does not establish its wisdom.

Alcohol may reduce inhibition.

That does not make it an ideal long-term scaffold.

Work can scaffold identity until unemployment becomes existential destruction.

A relationship can scaffold confidence until one person's approval receives too much jurisdiction.

A philosophy can scaffold interpretation until everything becomes one of its examples.

So ask:

What jurisdiction has the tool acquired?

A robust life may distribute support.

Friends.

Family.

Money.

Work.

Art.

Community.

Routine.

Institutions.

Places.

Ideas.

*The field remains larger than any one support.
This does not create a normative personality.
A quiet person may flourish.
A highly social person may flourish.
A person organized around routine may flourish.
A novelty-seeker may flourish.
Permeability does not require extroversion.
Curiosity does not require constant exploration.
Creativity does not require public production.
The flourishing person is not one personality type.
A better formulation is:*

Flourishing may increase an organism's responsible access to capacities its life requires and values.

*The direction of development may therefore differ.
One person needs more boundary.
Another more approach.
One more confidence.
Another more Fallibility.
One more rest.
Another Enactment.
One more Self-Regard.
Another Regard.
The good is not automatically the midpoint.
The Method asks what is missing and what has exceeded jurisdiction.
And capacities remain state-dependent.
Exhaustion changes judgment.
Pain changes patience.
Stress changes availability.
A skill accessible yesterday may feel remote today.
This helps us avoid moralizing every recurrence as regression.*

The practical question becomes:

What helps important capacities remain available across a wider range of conditions?

Sleep.

Money.

Routine.

Relationships.

Physical health.

Tools.

Practice.

Fewer unnecessary crises.

This introduces margin.

Material margin.

Emotional margin.

Temporal margin.

Relational margin.

Cognitive margin.

A life at permanent capacity is brittle.

One unexpected event threatens the whole structure.

Margin creates room for Error.

And the garden metaphor becomes useful again.

A garden is not a factory.

Paths occupy soil.

Shade exists.

Not every inch maximizes production.

Some space waits.

A flourishing life may need unused capacity.

Rest.

Savings.

Unstructured time.

Relationships that are not instrumentalized.

Attention not permanently allocated.

*Otherwise flourishing becomes another optimization project:
the person as corporation managing the asset called Self.*

The Self is Somebody.

Tools serve the life.

The life does not exist to justify the tools.

This is where neighboring disciplines should be allowed to interrupt us.

Neighboring Accounts of Flourishing

We did not invent flourishing.

Contemporary research does not even use the term in one settled way. A 2024 scoping review identified seven distinct flourishing measures; all were multidimensional, most incorporated both hedonic and eudaimonic elements, and the details varied substantially among scales (Rule et al. 2024).

Good.

Our Account should enter a crowded room.

One major neighbor is subjective well-being, commonly concerned with people's cognitive and emotional evaluations of their lives. Diener, Oishi, and Lucas describe it in terms of emotional and cognitive evaluations such as happiness and life satisfaction, while also noting influences from personality, circumstance, and culture (Diener, Oishi, and Lucas 2003).

Our framework needs this neighbor.

A theory that barely asks whether people enjoy their lives has probably become too impressed with itself.

Pleasure and satisfaction matter.

Yet subjective well-being does not exhaust what we mean.

Ryan and Deci's influential review distinguishes hedonic approaches focused on pleasure and pain avoidance from eudaimonic approaches focused on meaning, self-realization, and fuller functioning (Ryan and Deci 2001).

Our Account sits closer to the eudaimonic family.

Carol Ryff's model of psychological well-being includes autonomy, environmental mastery, personal growth, positive relations, purpose in life, and self-acceptance (Ryff 1989).

The overlap is obvious.

Growth resembles development.

Positive relations resemble Meeting.

Self-acceptance touches continuity without self-erasure.

Environmental mastery concerns effective participation in conditions.

But Ryff's framework also challenges us.

Our philosophy emphasizes corrigibility.

What about purpose?

We emphasize openness.

What about commitment?

A person could become extraordinarily revisable and build nothing.

Every identity provisional.

Every project experimental.

Every commitment perpetually reopenable.

That is not flourishing.

Eudaimonic traditions remind us that development also requires sustained form.

A garden whose beds are redesigned every morning grows little.

That insight has already changed our treatment of Revision.

Another close neighbor is psychological flexibility in Acceptance and Commitment Therapy.

A 2024 systematic and meta-analytic review of Acceptance and Commitment Therapy tracks processes including acceptance, present-moment awareness, cognitive defusion, values and committed action, and flexibility in relation to self-content;

changes in flexibility and inflexibility were associated with treatment-related reductions in distress (Macri and Rogge 2024).

The resemblance to permeability is substantial.

A thought can occur without automatically governing behavior.

An unwanted feeling can remain present while action continues.

Values can guide action under discomfort.

But permeability is not identical to psychological flexibility.

Our concept is explicitly epistemic and relational.

Can another person change my Account of them?

Can consequence change my causal theory?

Can Reality resist interpretation?

Still, ACT corrects one cognitive tendency in our vocabulary.

A person does not become impermeable only by rejecting evidence.

They can become impermeable by organizing life around avoiding internal experience.

The Wall can be built against the Self.

That belongs in our framework.

Resilience research creates another useful correction.

Rather than treating resilience as a permanent heroic trait, contemporary reviews often conceptualize it dynamically, varying across time and circumstance and involving protective resources (Stainton et al. 2019).

This supports our anti-totalization Account but also keeps it contextual.

Flow provides an almost opposite challenge.

Our philosophy contains enormous amounts of:

pause;

notice;

discriminate;

revise.

But some excellent human experiences involve reduced self-monitoring.

Flow research describes absorbed engagement marked by concentrated attention and, classically, features such as challenge-skill balance, clear goals, feedback, merging of action and awareness, and reduced self-consciousness (Peifer et al. 2022).

That reminds us:

one should not flourish while permanently standing outside oneself with a clipboard.

Conceptual equipment should sometimes recede.

The musician plays.

The conversation moves.

The person loves.

Method should support participation, not colonize it.

Self-efficacy provides another neighbor.

Research has long treated self-efficacy as belief in one's capacity to perform specific behavior (Lawrance and McLeroy 1986); experimental meta-analysis also indicates that interventions changing self-efficacy can change intentions and behavior (Sheeran et al. 2016).

That fits You Have to Reach the Wall.

Someone who believes no action is available may never create conditions for Answer.

But our framework distinguishes self-efficacy from entitlement to Outcome.

I can believe:

I can make this song.

*That does not become:
listeners must love it.*
So:

enough confidence for proportionate Enactment; enough
Fallibility for Answer to matter.

*These neighboring frameworks neither prove nor refute
ours.*
They cut the field differently.
That is the point.

Psychology can ask whether psychological flexibility predicts
well-being.

*Our question can remain:
What should be permitted to revise what?*
Resilience research can identify protective factors.
We can ask:
*When does praise of resilience conceal a condition that
should change?*
Subjective well-being can measure satisfaction.
We can ask:

How much jurisdiction should satisfaction receive if a life has
become impermeable?

Flow can study optimal absorption.
We can ask:
When should reflective Method get out of the way?

A philosophical Account need not become the master theory of
its neighbors.

Different tools Answer different questions.
Distributed jurisdiction again.
And that leads to one more correction.

Human flourishing may resist compression because human life contains several genuine goods.

Pleasure.

Meaning.

Agency.

Belonging.

Security.

Growth.

Purpose.

Relation.

Material support.

No single master variable may be owed to us.

Our own flourishing is therefore best treated as a developing relational capacity rather than one score.

The organism becomes increasingly capable of maintaining form without requiring rigidity; receiving Answer without collapsing; acting without certainty; revising without self-erasure; protecting boundaries without epistemic closure; and experiencing local difficulty without automatically making it total.

That Account may prove useful.

Another discipline may eventually decompose it more precisely.

Good.

The Method gets no exemption from Meeting.

Because after every theory has spoken, one ancient human wish remains unsatisfied.

We still want the harvest guaranteed.

It is not.

No Guaranteed Harvest

A garden can be cultivated well and fail.

So can a life project.

Good Desire.

Thoughtful Approach.

Strong Will.

Responsible Enactment.

Openness to Answer.

Revision.

And still:

no.

Other people decide.

Markets move.

Bodies fail.

Timing matters.

Institutions intervene.

Luck exists.

The individual organism never controls the whole causal field.

The Method may improve participation.

It cannot guarantee Outcome.

This is why:

a responsible decision can produce a bad Outcome.

And:

an irresponsible decision can produce a good Outcome.

Outcome should revise our causal Account.

It should not become the sole retroactive judge of whether the original action possessed Warrant.

*Otherwise hindsight rewrites uncertainty.
The successful choice becomes obviously wise.
The failed choice obviously foolish.
But Outcome launders uncertainty.
A screenplay submission is rejected.
That establishes rejection.
It does not automatically establish:
the script is bad;
submitting was foolish;
Edward lacks talent;
the Desire should be abandoned.
Likewise acceptance does not establish:
the script is excellent;
every causal theory Edward has about the success is
correct;
future success is guaranteed.
Repeated patterns matter.
Evidence accumulates.*

The organism should not say “bad luck” forever while repeating the same preventable failure.

*But harvest does not equal certification.
This makes visible Outcome a poor sole measure of
flourishing.
Money matters.
Housing matters.
Publication matters.
A produced movie differs from a script.
A finished record differs from an imagined song.
External Outcomes are real.
The philosophy should not counterfeit them with internal
development.
If rent is unpaid, flourishing does not pay it.*

But Outcome does not get everything either.

Several things can be cultivated simultaneously.

A project can fail commercially while teaching a skill.

It can succeed commercially while teaching the person that they dislike the activity.

A performance can go poorly while clarifying the Desire.

So:

failure of what?

The Approach?

The intended Outcome?

The causal theory?

The experiment?

The Desire?

The Self?

A failed Outcome does not automatically tell us which layer failed.

Sometimes Reality simply did not yield the Desired World.

This protects us from another fantasy of sovereignty:

If only I had optimized myself enough, every good Outcome would have been available.

No.

Sometimes there is no available move that produces the desired result.

Agency matters.

It does not own the field.

Edward's recent move into Southern California makes this distinction unusually concrete.

Before Enactment, there was an imagined geography.

Creative possibilities.

Services.

Work.

Housing possibilities.

Then he arrived.

The imagined city met actual transit, employers, shelters, distances, neighborhoods, fatigue, cost, and opportunity.

The original Approach began revising quickly.

That did not invalidate the Desire.

Hollywood did not need to remain central merely because it had been central in the plan.

Other areas became more attractive.

Ordinary work and reliable sleep acquired more immediate standing.

That is not reckless commitment.

It is Revision in contact with Reality.

And it reveals a distinction between results-oriented and move-oriented action.

Results-oriented action can become:

I did the brave thing.

Now where is the reward?

The organism searches subsequent events for links to the Desired Outcome.

This person might be the connection.

This coincidence might mean something.

This opportunity might prove the decision right.

The need for narrative continuity can make weak inferences feel strong.

Move-oriented enactment is different.

There remains a Desired World.

But the question becomes:

Given the position that actually exists now, what move is warranted?

Chess gives the better metaphor.

A plan matters until the board changes.

Then:

look again.

Reality's response is not necessarily a reward. It is a changed position.

Sometimes better.

Sometimes worse.

Sometimes ambiguous.

Courage does not create entitlement.

The brave action can fail.

The wise action can fail.

There is no promised reward.

But:

no promised reward does not mean no possible reward.

Pessimism can paint beyond the Wall too.

"I do not know that this works" is not "I know it will not."

Sometimes a better condition can only become reachable because the organism moves toward a position from which it can Answer.

That is Enactment under Limit.

This also gives us Necessary Successes.

A life becomes structurally fragile when too many Outcomes must go right simultaneously.

The job must work.

The housing must work.

The relationship must work.

The creative project must immediately produce money.

*The city must vindicate the move.
Every domain carries every other domain.
One failure propagates.
Flourishing may therefore involve something surprisingly
practical:
reducing the number of things that must go right at once.
This is structural margin.*

If ordinary work carries rent, art can receive creative Answer without every criticism becoming financial threat.

If sleep is stable, creative difficulty does not begin from bodily crisis.

If several relationships provide belonging, one disagreement need not become social annihilation.

This produces an important epistemic result:

Stability can protect the freedom to receive an honest Answer.

The less desperately an Outcome must be favorable, the easier it may become to hear what happened.

*This does not mean security is required for honesty.
It means cost structures affect permeability.
The person whose whole future depends on yes hears no differently.
Different supports can therefore receive smaller, cleaner jobs.
A job can be a job.
A bed can be a bed.
A conversation can be a conversation.
An opportunity can be an opportunity.
A rejection can be rejection.
None needs immediately to become destiny, salvation, or proof.*

This relates to an earlier experience of homelessness in which Edward was offered a bed and the possibility of a stabilizing relationship with someone who had substantial resources. Another Desire—prove myself—was also active. The opportunity could therefore become overloaded with the need to demonstrate loyalty, generosity, character, independence, perhaps by extending the invitation toward another homeless companion.

The generosity need not have been false.

Several Desires can be sincere simultaneously.

The useful question is:

What is this opportunity being asked to prove?

Sometimes a bed should simply be slept in.

That can be Method.

And this returns us to expectation.

A difficult night does not need to produce emotional collapse in order to be taken seriously.

Low money.

Poor sleep.

A crowded space.

Uncertainty.

These can all remain problems.

Cheerfulness does not negate them.

Nor does seriousness require distress to become total.

I do not need to experience total distress in order to acknowledge a local problem accurately.

Intensity does not create jurisdiction.

Neither does lack of intensity.

Past experience changes calibration.

Someone who has experienced much worse restrictions may understand a difficult night differently.

That knowledge can create capacity.

It should not become an excuse to remain in unnecessarily difficult conditions.

Resilience should serve cultivation.

Not endless endurance.

No guaranteed harvest.

And yet:

planting matters.

Cultivation changes what becomes possible without making possibility a promise.

That may be the heart of this movement.

The organism acts because something matters, an Approach has sufficient Warrant, and Enactment is part of how the future becomes available to Answer.

Then:

look again.

Enough to continue.

Cultivation Under Limit

We can now return to the garden.

A garden is cultivated.

Choose.

Prepare.

Plant.

Water.

Protect.

Prune.

Wait.

Learn.

Remove.

Leave alone.

Discover that something apparently dead was dormant.

Discover that something apparently healthy was consuming everything around it.

Cultivation is neither passive hope nor total control.

It is participation under conditions one does not completely author.

That is close to flourishing.

Not permanent happiness.

Not maximal pleasure.

Not endless growth.

Not invulnerability.

Not one personality type.

Not a reward for wisdom.

Not prosperity alone.

Not internal adaptation to whatever happens.

Flourishing concerns something like:

how an organism remains capable of living, acting, relating, receiving, and revising within a Reality that exceeds it.

Limit gives the structure.

Sometimes:

you have gone too far beyond Warrant.

Stop painting.

Sometimes:

you have not gone far enough to know.

Move.

This gives us a different picture of courage.

Not:

I know this will work.

But:

I possess enough Warrant to move despite not knowing whether it will.

That courage can coexist with fear.

Revision.

Retreat.

Failure.

No single capacity can govern cultivation.

Curiosity needs Limit.

Limit needs Curiosity.

Confidence needs Fallibility.

Fallibility needs enough confidence to act.

Permeability needs boundary.

Boundary needs openings.

Resilience needs material critique.

Material critique must leave room for agency.

Self-Regard needs Regard.

Regard must not erase the Self.

Revision needs continuity.

Continuity must not become captivity.

Imagination proposes.

Reality Answers.

The point is not to occupy the middle.

Different organisms need different things.

The Method asks:

What is missing?

What has received too much jurisdiction?

And what does this organism actually value?

Because the Self matters.

Anti-sovereignty should not become anti-Self.

The organism is not merely a location where external Answers accumulate.

It possesses Desire.

Taste.

History.

Commitment.

Imagination.

Projects.

A body.

Something like authorship.

Its inability to author everything does not mean it authors nothing.

A life is co-authored without being authorless.

Edward participates.

Others participate.

Institutions.

History.

Bodies.

Chance.

Tools.

Material conditions.

None possesses causal monopoly.

This makes responsibility possible without pretending sovereignty.

I contributed.

I did not cause everything.

I was harmed.

The harm does not explain everything.

I succeeded.

My virtues are not necessarily the whole cause.

I failed.

I am not the failure.

This is distributed authorship.

It is not equally distributed.

Some people begin with enormous resources.

Others with enormous burdens.

Prosperity can purchase margin:

time;

privacy;

healthcare;

mobility;

education;

safety;

second chances;

the ability to leave.

The lack of these should never be converted into inferiority of character.

And prosperity should not become invisible merely because flourishing is our subject.

A person flourishing under hardship still deserves better conditions.

Resilience is not rent.

Meaning is not food.

Perspective is not medicine.

The flourishing organism therefore moves in two directions.

It becomes better able to meet Reality.

And where possible, it changes local conditions so that less damage must be endured merely to keep meeting Reality.

Sometimes adaptation.

Sometimes refusal.

Sometimes departure.

Sometimes rebuilding.

Sometimes asking for help.

Sometimes accepting help without requiring that help to define the Self.

Plural dependence supports this.

The fantasy of total independence dissolves quickly.

Humans use roads they did not build.

Languages they did not invent.

Knowledge inherited from strangers.

Institutions.

Technologies.

Relationships.

Medicine.

Tools.

The question is not whether dependence exists.

It is what form it takes and what jurisdiction it acquires.

Different supports can carry different loads.

Love need not solve mortality.

Work need not contain the whole Self.

*Art need not immediately pay rent.
A temporary shelter need not become Home to provide sleep.
A city need not prove identity.
A success need not prove destiny.
A failure need not become ontology.
That is structural cleanliness.*

And perhaps it creates what the whole Method has really been trying to preserve:

the possibility of Answer.
No.
Yes.
Not yet.
Different than expected.
I disagree.
You hurt me.
I love you.
I am leaving.
Try again.
This works.
This doesn't.
I don't know.

A flourishing organism may increasingly be able to let such Answers matter without requiring them to become everything.

*That is permeability with continuity.
Love gives the hardest example.
Commitment needs continuity.
A relationship cannot restart every morning.
So Love can say:
this passing feeling does not automatically decide us.
But Love becomes Paint when it says:
nothing can ever Answer us.*

The harder possibility is:

remain,

and remain reachable.

Commit,

and remain corrigible.

Love without requiring exhaustive explanation.

Revise without allowing every fluctuation to become referendum.

I know this matters.

I do not fully know why.

Something has changed.

I do not yet know how far that change reaches.

I meant what I said.

I understand differently now.

And I remain accountable.

That is not a weaker commitment than certainty.

It may be the only commitment available to Fallible beings across Time.

The same structure applies to the Self.

Enough continuity to say:

I.

Enough permeability for the I to remain unfinished.

I was wrong.

Not:

I was fraudulent.

I changed.

Not:

the earlier person never existed.

I caused harm.

Not:

I am only harmful.

I succeeded.

Not:

everything about me is thereby vindicated.

This is Revision without self-erasure.

It also explains why a sufficiently secure Self may become more corrigible.

When Error does not threaten annihilation, the organism has fewer incentives to defend Error forever.

So flourishing need not mean fewer difficult Moments.

Where possible, of course, fewer unnecessary difficulties are good.

It may mean difficult Moments receive less unnecessary jurisdiction.

The insult remains insulting.

The rejection remains rejection.

The anxious day remains anxious.

The mistake remains a mistake.

The difficult relationship Moment remains difficult.

The field remains larger than the event.

Flourishing must therefore contain non-flourishing Moments.

Otherwise it becomes another performance standard.

Am I flourishing correctly?

Was I sufficiently permeable?

Did I map every cause?

Did I revise proportionately?

Sometimes Edward is tired.

Wrong.

Irritable.

Confused.

Sometimes the old pattern returns.

*A garden contains wilted leaves.
Flourishing is not horticultural perfection.
This is why enough matters more than maximum.
Enough Warrant to move.
Enough confidence to try.
Enough Fallibility to listen.
Enough boundary to remain Somebody.
Enough permeability for something else to matter.
Enough resilience that one event does not become everything.
Enough commitment for things to deepen.
Enough Revision that depth does not become captivity.
Enough imagination to propose.
Enough Limit to remember the proposal is not Reality.
Enough Desire to cultivate.
Enough humility to know Desire cannot command harvest.
Perhaps flourishing is partly an enoughness under incompleteness.
Not:
this is good enough forever.
Rather:*

I do not need the final state before I can responsibly inhabit the present one.

*I can want the harvest and still live in the garden.
The Desired World matters.
The home.
The Love.
The book.
The film.
The song.
The income.
The safer condition.*

None needs to be trivialized merely because it remains distant.

But a life permanently deferred until the Desired World arrives becomes uninhabitable.

So:

cultivate.

And live.

The present Approach returns to its jurisdiction.

What is available now?

Then:

what position exists now?

Not:

where is my reward?

What has become available?

What has closed?

What changed?

What remains warranted?

What needs patience?

What needs Revision?

What needs another move?

That is cultivation under Limit.

Its optimism is modest.

It does not say:

things work out.

Sometimes they do not.

It does not say:

everything happens for a reason.

Events have causes; that is different.

It does not say:

the universe rewards courage.

No contract exists.

Its optimism is smaller:

because the future is not yet completely Answered, possibility remains proportionate to what has not yet been settled.

Pessimism gets no more sovereignty than optimism.

"I do not know whether this works" is not "I know it cannot."

Hope can therefore remain without becoming prediction.

I want this.

I can imagine it.

I do not know whether it arrives.

I presently possess an Approach worth trying.

Let us see.

Perhaps that is enough.

And perhaps Curiosity returns at the end in a different form.

At first:

What else might be true?

Now:

What can still happen from here?

Not compulsively.

Sometimes the Answer is:

nothing here that I should continue pursuing.

Then the Path bends.

Philosophy has done enough when it produces orientation rather than permanent self-monitoring.

Not:

Here is Reality.

But:

Here are some ways to remember the difference between Paint and Wall.

Not:

Here is the correct life.

But:

Here are some questions that might keep your life answerable while you live it.

Not:

Here is how to flourish.

But:

Here is one Account of what may be happening when one flourishes.

When one flourishes, perhaps nothing supernatural occurs.

The person has not escaped Limit.

They have become better able to live within it.

The Wall remains.

The Other remains Other.

The future remains partly unavailable.

The Self remains Fallible.

Pain.

Loss.

Error.

Failure.

All remain possible.

And yet the garden is not therefore barren.

Revision is possible because Account is not Reality.

Meeting is possible because the Other is not the Account.

Action is possible because uncertainty is not prohibition.

Hope is possible because absence of guarantee is not guarantee of absence.

Responsibility is possible because incomplete causation does not erase participation.

Love is possible because Limit need not destroy significance.

Continuity is possible because Revision need not erase.

Joy is possible because pleasure does not need to certify the whole life.

Flourishing is possible because flourishing never required perfection.

And sometimes the gardener should simply sit inside the garden.

Eat something.

Laugh.

Rest.

Love somebody.

Listen to the fucking song.

Not everything must become material for improvement.

Sometimes the fruit is fruit.

That is a Limit on philosophy too.

A Path Continues

*A path does not become false because it continues.
 We like endings because they make interpretation easier.
 From the end, a person says:
 That was the turning point.
 That was the mistake.
 That was why it happened.
 That was what it meant.
 The living person does not possess that advantage.
 We act before the whole path is visible.
 Commit before every future Self has arrived.
 Love without exhaustive causal explanation.
 Interpret from histories still capable of receiving Answer.
 Build gardens under weather we do not command.
 Reach Walls without knowing what lies beyond them.
 Then continue.
 That unfinishedness is not an embarrassment philosophy
 should solve.
 It may be the condition in which philosophy matters.*

This essay began with one organism reporting that his life seemed better.

*The claim remains.
 It has not become proof.
 Edward is unfinished.
 Projects remain unresolved.
 Material conditions remain capable of changing radically.
 The concepts may fail somewhere important.
 Future Edward may revise this Account.*

Good.

Flourishing cannot require completion because a living person is unfinished by definition.

The question is what relation the organism develops to that fact.

One possibility is permanent deferral.

I cannot begin until I become someone else.

I cannot rest until the work succeeds.

I cannot trust myself until uncertainty disappears.

I cannot love until I know what Love guarantees.

I cannot live until the Desired World arrives.

Another is surrender.

Nothing is guaranteed.

Therefore nothing matters.

No Account is final.

Therefore all Accounts are equal.

Reality exceeds me.

Therefore my participation means nothing.

Between them lies something more ordinary.

Participation.

I know something.

Not everything.

I want something.

Not sovereignty.

I can move.

Not command.

I can commit.

Not imprison the future.

I can revise.

Not erase the past.

I can love.

Not possess.

I can hope.

Not predict.

I can cultivate.

Not guarantee harvest.

Perhaps that is enough structure for a life.

And the word one matters.

When One Flourishes.

One case.

One life.

One garden.

One Path.

Another organism may require radically different equipment.

Different boundaries.

Different forms of courage.

Different communities.

Different material support.

Different Answers.

The questions may travel farther than the answers.

Does this Account remain capable of Answer?

Does the Other remain Somebody?

Does the Self?

Has confidence outrun Warrant?

Has doubt?

Has one event become too large?

Has a commitment become impermeable?

Has Revision become indiscriminate?

Is prosperity being mistaken for flourishing?

Is flourishing being used to excuse the absence of prosperity?

Did Reality Answer, or did I Answer on its behalf?

What position actually exists now?

These questions can orient without dictating.

Perhaps, with practice, even they recede.
A person simply notices:
I am assuming something.
I should ask.
I know enough to act.
I do not know enough to condemn.
This matters, but it does not get everything.
I was wrong.
I still have to deal with what I did.
I love this person.
I cannot fully explain why.
Something needs to change.
I do not yet know how much.
I want this.
I am not owed it.
This failed.
Another move may remain.
That is philosophy returning to life.
Not philosophy narrating life continuously from above.
Eventually:
look up.
The world is still there.
The Other.
The body.
The next conversation.
The meal.
The work.
The street.
The song.
The person beside you.
Life will not obey the essay.
Good.

It will produce cases we did not anticipate.

Criticisms.

Exceptions.

New evidence.

Better concepts.

People whose lives expose the provinciality of ours.

If the Method is serious, it already knows the response.

Meet them.

Not submit automatically.

A new Answer can be wrong.

A criticism can misunderstand.

Permeability is not obedience.

Receive.

Discriminate.

Test jurisdiction.

Revise what has been earned.

Continue.

This is why the Path cannot become The Path.

The moment it becomes immune to displacement, the concepts become Paint.

The Paint becomes Wall.

The garden becomes display.

And flourishing becomes another identity that must be defended.

Better to leave the gate open.

Not completely.

A garden without boundary is not necessarily a garden.

Open enough.

For weather.

Pollination.

A neighbor.

An unexpected plant.

For something not chosen that nevertheless deserves a place.

This may also be why beginnings and endings are so philosophically dangerous.

At beginnings, the unknown becomes Paint:

This will become everything.

At endings:

Nothing remains.

Both are Walls.

A flourishing response need not flatten either.

The beginning can remain thrilling.

The ending devastating.

Limit does not regulate the intensity of feeling.

It regulates what feeling is required to prove.

At a beginning:

Something has become possible.

Let us see what it becomes.

At an ending:

Something has ended.

Let us see what remains capable of beginning.

That does not turn loss into secret opportunity.

Some losses are not redeemed.

Some possibilities disappear permanently.

Reality retains appeal even against philosophical beauty.

But the field may still remain larger than the event.

That is not a promise about the future.

It is a Limit on what the present permits us to say about the whole.

And so we return to the Wall.

Humans paint.

We should.

Imagination creates futures before they exist.
Love colors perception.
Art rearranges Reality.
Hope reaches beyond evidence without needing to become knowledge.
The discipline is not:
stop painting.
It is:
remember where the Wall is.
Let Paint remain Paint.
And when Reality supplies something new:
look again.
Maybe that is all Revision finally asks.
Not endless destruction.
Not betrayal.
Not permanent doubt.
Look again.
Perhaps the Account survives.
Perhaps one line changes.
Perhaps the whole Mural eventually has to come down.
The Answer earns the Revision.
Until then, inhabit what can responsibly be inhabited.
This is why flourishing can look remarkably ordinary.
A person encounters a problem.
Does not make it five.
Encounters uncertainty.
Does not manufacture certainty.
Encounters pleasure.
Enjoys it.
Encounters rejection.
Lets it hurt.
Encounters opportunity.

Considers it.

Encounters another person.

Leaves somewhere for them to stand.

Encounters themselves.

Does not require final definition.

Then tomorrow arrives.

No trumpet.

No certification.

Another day.

Another set of Answers.

Another chance to participate.

The garden does not announce that it is flourishing.

It grows where it can.

Changes shape.

Survives some seasons.

Fails in others.

The gardener changes too.

And sometimes, without requiring the Moment to mean anything more than it means, the gardener notices:

something here is alive.

Perhaps that is enough.

Not enough forever.

Enough now.

Enough to continue.

Enough to remain answerable.

Enough to love without possession.

Enough to act without guarantee.

Enough to revise without disappearing.

Enough to want the harvest and still live in the garden.

A Path continues.

And because it continues, the final word does not belong to this Account.

It belongs to whatever Answers next.

REFERENCES

- Cannon, Ed W. 2026a. "Good Talk: Kairotic Affordance and the Ethics of Disclosure." Unpublished manuscript.
- Cannon, Ed W. 2026b. "On Rose-Colored Paint and Romance." Unpublished manuscript.
- Diener, Ed, Shigehiro Oishi, and Richard E. Lucas. 2003. "Personality, Culture, and Subjective Well-Being: Emotional and Cognitive Evaluations of Life." *Annual Review of Psychology* 54: 403–425. <https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev.psych.54.101601.145056>.
- Heidegger, Martin. 1968. *What Is Called Thinking?* Translated by Fred D. Wieck and J. Glenn Gray. New York: Harper & Row. Original German edition published 1954.
- Lawrance, Lynne, and Kenneth R. McLeroy. 1986. "Self-Efficacy and Health Education." *Journal of School Health* 56 (8): 317–321. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1746-1561.1986.tb05761.x>.
- Macri, Jenna A., and Ronald D. Rogge. 2024. "Examining Domains of Psychological Flexibility and Inflexibility as Treatment Mechanisms in Acceptance and Commitment Therapy: A Comprehensive Systematic and Meta-Analytic Review." *Clinical Psychology Review* 110: 102432. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cpr.2024.102432>.
- Nietzsche, Friedrich. 1883–1885. *Thus Spake Zarathustra: A Book for All and None*. Translated by Thomas Common. Project Gutenberg eBook #1998, released 1999; updated 2023. <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/1998>.
- Peifer, Corinna, Gina Wolters, László Harmat, Jean Heutte, Jasmine Tan, Teresa Freire, Dionísia Tavares, Carla Fonte, Frans Orsted Andersen, Jef van den Hout, Milija Šimleša, Linda Pola, Lucia Ceja, and Stefano Triberti. 2022. "A Scoping Review of Flow Research." *Frontiers in Psychology* 13: 815665. <https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2022.815665>.
- Rule, Andrew, Cody Abbey, Huan Wang, Scott Rozelle, and Manpreet K. Singh. 2024. "Measurement of Flourishing: A Scoping Review." *Frontiers in Psychology* 15: 1293943. <https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2024.1293943>.
- Ryan, Richard M., and Edward L. Deci. 2001. "On Happiness and Human Potentials: A Review of Research on Hedonic and Eudaimonic Well-Being." *Annual Review of Psychology* 52: 141–166. <https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev.psych.52.1.141>.
- Ryff, Carol D. 1989. "Happiness Is Everything, or Is It? Explorations on the Meaning of Psychological Well-Being." *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology* 57 (6): 1069–1081. <https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.57.6.1069>.

- Sheeran, Paschal, Alexander Maki, Erika Montanaro, Aya Avishai-Yitshak, Angela Bryan, William M. P. Klein, Eleanor Miles, and Alexander J. Rothman. 2016. "The Impact of Changing Attitudes, Norms, and Self-Efficacy on Health-Related Intentions and Behavior: A Meta-Analysis." *Health Psychology* 35 (11): 1178–1188. <https://doi.org/10.1037/hea0000387>.
- Stainton, Alexandra, Katharine Chisholm, Nathalie Kaiser, Marlene Rosen, Rachel Upthegrove, Stephan Ruhrmann, and Stephen J. Wood. 2019. "Resilience as a Multimodal Dynamic Process." *Early Intervention in Psychiatry* 13 (4): 725–732. <https://doi.org/10.1111/eip.12726>.

CONTINUE THE INQUIRY

When One Flourishes is part of the developing philosophical project behind the *For Those Curious* series.

For Those Curious; A Method of Meeting

For Those Still Curious; Meeting Ourselves Over Time

Meeting Murals

edwardcgruchacz.github.io

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Ed W Cannon writes philosophy and fiction about interpretation, meeting, desire, human–AI collaboration, and the limits of certainty. His work asks how people can remain answerable to Reality and to one another without surrendering imagination, commitment, or the possibility of Revision.